

WHO Postnatal Care Guidelines: Maternal Wellbeing and Postpartum Support

1. Postpartum Mental Health (Baby Blues vs Postpartum Depression):

The 'baby blues' are common, affecting up to 80% of mothers in the first two weeks, involving mild mood changes and crying spells. It usually resolves without treatment.

Postpartum Depression (PPD) is a serious medical condition affecting 10-15% of mothers, involving persistent sadness, severe anxiety, extreme fatigue, difficulty bonding with the baby, and feelings of worthlessness. WHO recommends screening all mothers for PPD at postpartum checkups (typically at 6 weeks).

2. Support and Recovery:

Ensure adequate rest, accept help from family/friends, and engage in light physical activity when cleared by a doctor. Counseling, support groups, and cognitive behavioral therapy are highly effective first-line treatments for PPD.

3. Newborn Care and Bonding:

Skin-to-skin contact immediately after birth and during the early weeks promotes bonding, regulates the baby's temperature, and supports breastfeeding initiation.